

AUDIOBOOK COMPANION

AT YOUR BEST

*How to Get Time, Energy, and Priorities
Working in Your Favor*

Carey Nieuwhof

FOLLOW-ALONG OUTLINE

& Get Me There Action Guide

Live in a way today that will help you thrive tomorrow.

THE FRAMEWORK

Stress Spiral vs. Thrive Cycle

Two patterns. One choice. Repeated daily.

Carey Nieuwhof's central claim is that stress and thriving are both **patterns** — and patterns are repeatable. The Stress Spiral and the Thrive Cycle are mirror images, each built on three forces: **time, energy, and priorities**. The maxim that runs through every chapter is simple: *do what you're best at when you're at your best*.

THE STRESS SPIRAL

1. **Unfocused time** — every hour treated as equal, the most important work squeezed into leftovers.
2. **Unleveraged energy** — peak hours wasted; deep work attempted when you're at your worst.
3. **Hijacked priorities** — other people's agendas eat your day; the things you said mattered most are exactly the things that don't get done.

THE THRIVE CYCLE

1. **Focused time** — pre-decided. You schedule your priorities before others do it for you.
 2. **Leveraged energy** — you discover your 3-5 peak hours (Green Zone) and protect them like a sanctuary.
 3. **Realized priorities** — Pareto applied to tasks *and* people. The right work gets done, with the right people, at the right time.
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THE THREE ZONES

Green Zone — your 3-5 peak hours. Creative, alert, in flow. *Spend it on what you're best at and what has the highest impact.*

Yellow Zone — moderate energy. *Use it for meetings, planning, recurring work that matters but isn't peak-effort.*

Red Zone — low energy. *Email, exercise, errands, low-stakes admin. Never make big decisions here.*

THE MANTRA

Live in a way today that will help you thrive tomorrow.

Thriving is measured across five domains: **spiritual, relational, emotional, financial, physical**. Winning at work while losing at home means you're losing.

PART 01

This Much Stress Is Not Okay

Diagnose the Stress Spiral and what it costs.

CHAPTER

01

Build a Life You Don't Want to Escape From

Why most of us secretly resent the life and career we've so carefully built

audiobook 07:20

EPIGRAPH

"What we call our despair is often only the painful eagerness of unfed hope."

— George Eliot

CORE LESSON

The life you carefully build can betray you when you run it at an unsustainable pace. Survival is not a worthy goal; thriving is.

KEY STORIES & EXAMPLES

The driveway moment. Sitting in the car at dusk, too drained to walk into his own house, fantasizing about quitting to go work in a warehouse where the boxes, unlike people, stay stacked.

Burnout in 2006. Despite a growing church and a healthy family from the outside, the unsustainable pace caved in on itself; passion gone, energy sapped, hope flickering.

Dallas keynote poll. Of 800 leaders surveyed live in the room, 93% said they had wrestled with burnout symptoms in the past year. Only 7% said never.

CAREY'S TAKEAWAYS

1. Stop calling it a season. If your busy season has no end, it isn't a season — it's your life.
2. Burn the cultural script that says exhaustion is the price of success.
3. Get honest about the cost of chronic stress on body, marriage, and dreams.
4. Decide that this is fixable — most of it traces back to how you spend your time, energy, and priorities.

CHAPTER
02

No More Crazy Busy Life

Live in a way today that will help you thrive tomorrow

audiobook 36:00

EPIGRAPH

"Anxiety is the dizziness of freedom."

— Soren Kierkegaard

CORE LESSON

There is a Stress Spiral and a Thrive Cycle. Both are patterns. You can swap one for the other by changing how you treat time, energy, and priorities.

KEY STORIES & EXAMPLES

The sabbatical illusion. Time off won't heal you when the problem is how you spend your time on. A sustainable pace is the only solution to an unsustainable pace.

Buying when others are selling. Sometimes the way through is doing the opposite of what everyone else is doing — including with personal habits.

CAREY'S TAKEAWAYS

1. Stress Spiral = unfocused time + unleveraged energy + hijacked priorities.
 2. Thrive Cycle = focused time + leveraged energy + realized priorities.
 3. Adopt the maxim: live in a way today that will help you thrive tomorrow.
 4. Define thriving across all five domains — spiritual, relational, emotional, financial, physical — not just work.
 5. Margin (calendar, energy, money, attention) is what makes thriving possible.
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PART 02

Focus Your Time

Stop spending time randomly; tell the truth about it.

CHAPTER
03

You Actually Do Have the Time

Two critical mental shifts about time

audiobook 1:05:36

EPIGRAPH

"I looked for balanced people doing anything good in the world. I couldn't find many."

— Danielle Strickland

CORE LESSON

Time management is efficiency; thriving requires effectiveness. Two mental shifts unlock everything: tell the truth about time, and trade balance for passion.

KEY STORIES & EXAMPLES

The President has the same 24 hours. The realization driving home one night that the most powerful person on the planet has the same daily allotment as everyone else — which means time isn't the real shortage.

Saying no to Rich. The 6pm phone call he didn't take — and the moment he stopped saying 'I don't have time' for the rest of his life.

The two guys on the porch. Riding past relaxed neighbors on a sunny afternoon and resenting them — until realizing he, too, had the time; he just wasn't choosing to take it.

CAREY'S TAKEAWAYS

1. Replace 'I don't have time' with 'I didn't make the time.' Excuses kill dreams; truth restores agency.
2. Use the truth-teller line internally; soften it externally so you don't burn bridges.
3. Abandon balance as a goal — it tends to be a retreat. Embrace passion instead, on a curated few priorities.
4. Run passion through five filters (spiritual, relational, emotional, financial, physical) so you don't end up like Jobs or Musk relationally.
5. Build a Dream List of 3-5 things and people you wish you had more time for, with target hours per week.

CHAPTER

04

Find Your Green Zone

How to uncover when you're at your best

audiobook 1:28:28

EPIGRAPH

"I write only when inspiration strikes. Fortunately, it strikes every morning at 9 o'clock sharp."

— Steven Pressfield (quoting Maugham)

CORE LESSON

Most people only have three to five truly productive, high-energy hours per day. Find yours — that's your Green Zone.

KEY STORIES & EXAMPLES

Falling asleep in Scranton. Conducting a job interview at a Chili's near midnight after a 7-hour drive — and dozing off mid-question. Evidence that not all hours are equal.

The 9am vs 4pm surgery. Anesthesia adverse events run ~1% at 9am and ~4.2% at 4pm; colonoscopy detection drops 5% per hour as the day wears on.

Daniel Pink's distribution. About 14% are morning people, 21% night owls, and 65% in the middle — but everyone has only 3-5 truly peak hours per day.

CAREY'S TAKEAWAYS

1. Map your Energy Clock: Green (peak), Yellow (mid), Red (low) by hour of the day.
2. Track both productivity and mood — not just one.
3. Don't pretend you have eight Green Zone hours. Three leveraged hours beat ten unleveraged ones.
4. Get input from people who see you (spouse, coworkers) — they spot things you miss.
5. Your zones can change over time; revisit and adjust regularly.

PART 03

Leverage Your Energy

Do what you're best at when you're at your best.

CHAPTER
05

Do What You're Best At

Investing your energy for the highest returns

audiobook 1:52:13

EPIGRAPH

"You must match time's swiftness with your speed in using it. You must drink quickly, as though from a rapid stream that will not always flow."

— Seneca

CORE LESSON

Optimal Green Zone Focus = Gifting x Passion x Impact. Develop your gift in your peak hours; don't merely use it.

KEY STORIES & EXAMPLES

The two stocks producing 80%. If two of ten stocks consistently produced 80% of returns, you'd reweight your portfolio. Most people invest time the way no one would invest money.

Guitar with Jordan. Carey learned two chords in three years; his musically-gifted son passed him in eight minutes. Skill cannot fully replace gifting.

Gladwell's 10,000 hours. World-class talent = raw gifting + 10,000 deliberate hours. Most people use their gift but never develop it — and the world loses the difference.

CAREY'S TAKEAWAYS

1. Identify your gifting — what feels effortless to you that others find hard.
2. Identify your passion — tasks that energize rather than drain you.
3. Identify highest impact — the few activities that move the needle most for your mission.
4. Stop wasting Green Zone on breakfast meetings, inbox triage, or tasks you simply dislike.
5. Spend at least 30 Green-Zone minutes a day developing your gift, not just delivering it.

CHAPTER
06**Yellow Zone, Red Zone, and Other Real-Life Problems***How to leverage non-optimal times and situations*

audiobook 2:18:43

EPIGRAPH*"Terrible things can happen when you're overtired."*

— William Goldman

CORE LESSON

Match remaining tasks to remaining energy. Yellow zones do moderate work; red zones do low-stakes work. Never make important decisions in your red zone.

KEY STORIES & EXAMPLES

Workouts in the red zone. Carey moved exercise to 4-6pm — his red zone. Movement reboots his system without burning peak hours.

Be like a normal dad. His son Jordan once asked why he couldn't just be around like normal dads. Showing up isn't a guarantee — but not showing up guarantees nothing relational happens.

128 of 168 hours. A 40-hour workweek is only 24% of the week — the math says most people control far more of their lives than they think.

CAREY'S TAKEAWAYS

1. Yellow Zone: meetings, recurring planning, podcasts/interviews, calendar work.
2. Red Zone: email, expense reports, exercise, low-stakes administration.
3. Real-life challenge #1 (no calendar control): you control more than you think — usually 88%+ of your week.
4. Real-life challenge #2 (not the CEO): shift what you can; ask, don't demand; be so good they want to accommodate you.
5. Real-life challenge #3 (young kids / hard season): adjust expectations and play the long game; not being around guarantees nothing happens.

PART 04

Realize Your Priorities

Defend the work that matters from the people and tasks that don't.

CHAPTER
07**Hijacked***Why it's so easy to fall perpetually behind*

audiobook 2:40:54

EPIGRAPH*"Hard choices, easy life. Easy choices, hard life."*

— Jerzy Gregorek

CORE LESSON

Nobody will ever ask you to accomplish your priorities — they'll only ask you to accomplish theirs. Defend yours with three moves: narrow focus, master the clear no, and make categorical decisions.

KEY STORIES & EXAMPLES

The day that disintegrated. An 'open' day vaporized into Sarah's five-minute knock, Justin's two-hour brain pick, Frank's text, an inbox war, and a 4:17pm coffee walk — none of it on the original list.

Eleven inboxes. Email plus DMs plus message requests across platforms — no wonder peace is elusive.

COVID-19 categorical decisions. South by Southwest and a five-city Australia tour vanished overnight, demonstrating how powerful eliminating entire categories of activity can be.

CAREY'S TAKEAWAYS

1. Apply Pareto: spend 80% of your time on the 20% of activities that produce 80% of your results.
2. Master the 5-step clear no: (1) 'I'd love to' (2) empathy (3) firm decline (4) redirect to a better fit (5) thanks.
3. Make categorical decisions — eliminate whole types of meetings/requests so you don't decide one-by-one.
4. Categorical examples: no breakfast meetings, no weekend meetings, only speaking to leaders, pre-chosen charities.
5. FOMO is the enemy. Saying yes to a stupid meeting steals from your son's football game.

CHAPTER
08**Distraction-Free***How to stop interrupting yourself*

audiobook 3:13:44

EPIGRAPH*"The greatest weariness comes from work not done."*

— Eric Hoffer

CORE LESSON

Optimize where, when, and how. The opposite of distraction is traction — and traction requires environment, silence, motion, and rest.

KEY STORIES & EXAMPLES

2,617 phone touches. Average users touch their phones 2,617 times a day; heavy users 5,427. Imagine a human ringing your doorbell that often.

Twain's cabin and Nabokov's bathtub. Writers across centuries have built sanctuaries — even Nabokov wrote in the tub when no desk would fit.

LeBron's ten hours. Elite athletes treat sleep as a competitive weapon. Pro athletes choose prehab over rehab.

CAREY'S TAKEAWAYS

1. Find or build the most undistracted environment you can for your Green Zone.
2. Turn off all notifications. Default-on is theirs; on-your-schedule is yours.
3. Use motion to think — Steve Jobs's walks, Nietzsche's daily walks. Best ideas come when the body is moving.
4. Early mornings carry an edge: the world's noise hasn't started yet.
5. Sleep is non-negotiable. A focused you is a better you.

CHAPTER
09

What About People?

What to do when the wrong people want your attention and the right people don't

audiobook 3:38:30

EPIGRAPH

"Love is something more stern and splendid than mere kindness."

— C.S. Lewis

CORE LESSON

The people who want your time are rarely the people who should have it. Apply Pareto to relationships and respond to depth with depth.

KEY STORIES & EXAMPLES

Grandma and Nancy. Daily phone calls from Nancy that no hint could end — until grandma sent young Carey outside to pretend he needed her, finally giving her a way out.

Dunbar's circles. Humans are wired for ~3-5 intimate friendships, ~12-15 close friends, and ~150 meaningful contacts. Beyond that, capacity collapses.

Friends, fans, and followers. Digital proximity gives 750+ people access to you and breaks the relational design — overwhelm is mathematically inevitable.

CAREY'S TAKEAWAYS

1. Limit time with two categories: those you feel you should meet but don't want to (flat learning curves) and those who want to but don't need to (drainers).
2. Invest 80% of relational time in your top performers (work) and inner circle (life).
3. Use Dunbar's numbers as your digital filter: protect the 3-5 and 12-15 first.
4. Match response speed to relationship depth — family/inner circle within the hour, tribe same-day, everyone else later or not at all.
5. Stop people-pleasing the wrong people; that's exactly how the right people get left behind.

PART 05

Theory Meets Real Life

Make it stick. Recalibrate when life pushes back.

CHAPTER
10

The Big Sync

How to synchronize your time, energy, and priorities every day

audiobook 4:11:04

EPIGRAPH

"You don't think your way into a new kind of living, but live your way into a new kind of thinking."

— Henri Nouwen

CORE LESSON

Blank space on your calendar isn't freedom — it's an invitation for hijacking. The Thrive Calendar is a pre-decision about how to spend your time.

KEY STORIES & EXAMPLES

Jason at the board meeting. What are you doing Saturday? — said yes to a party because the calendar was blank, ruined his only family day, and learned that blank space is a trap.

Hemingway's morning routine. Wrote at first light every day, until he had a place 'where you still have your juice and know what will happen next.' Pre-decision in action.

CAREY'S TAKEAWAYS

1. Decide how you'll spend your time before others decide for you.
2. Four design decisions: what (in each zone), who (you'll meet with), when (specific tasks), where (your work happens).
3. Schedule your Green Zone first; let yellow and red zones absorb the rest.
4. Write personal/family time onto the calendar — or it gets eaten.
5. Five markers it's working: priorities are getting done, you're developing your gift, meetings are energizing, you have time for self/family, you're happier.

CHAPTER
11**Thrive On***How to recalibrate when life blows up your perfectly crafted plan*

audiobook 4:36:18

EPIGRAPH*"No battle plan survives contact with the enemy."*

— Military axiom

CORE LESSON

Stress doesn't stay gone. Anticipate, recalibrate, and do the math on three ratios that quietly govern your sustainability.

KEY STORIES & EXAMPLES

Stress as a badge of honor. Stress is sneakily attractive — even as we hate it, we feel suspicious without it. Breaking up with stress is a long-term project.

The 300,000-mile SUV. Preventative maintenance — done before things broke — kept it running. Same principle applies to a life.

CAREY'S TAKEAWAYS

1. Act as soon as you anticipate change (new baby, promotion, move, loss). Adjust before the wave hits.
2. Recalibrate fast: audit your real time use, redo your zones, rethink categories.
3. Do the math on three ratios: time alone vs with people; time in meetings; time at home vs on the road.
4. Each person has an optimal mix and a meeting cap — find yours and respect it.
5. Healthy at the top means healthy at the bottom. Your team adopts your patterns.

CHAPTER
12

Hello from the Future You

It's not just what you accomplish — it's who you're becoming

audiobook 5:03:05

EPIGRAPH

"What our life amounts to, at least for those who reach full age, is largely, if not entirely, a matter of what we become within."

— Dallas Willard

CORE LESSON

The deepest payoff of the Thrive Cycle isn't productivity — it's character. Being at your best is about who you become, not just what you ship.

KEY STORIES & EXAMPLES

The camping rule. Years after vowing never to camp again, Carey returned with his now-grown sons under one rule: no complaining. The trip was wet, hard, and wonderful.

The drive home conversation. His son asked why he had hated camping. The honest answer included tears and the regret of being an anxious dad in years he can't get back.

CAREY'S TAKEAWAYS

1. Imagine yourself in 10, 20, or 30 years. Who are you becoming, not just what are you achieving?
2. Productivity is a side effect of formation, not the goal itself.
3. Some early years can't be reclaimed — but the next chapter can be lived differently.
4. Long obedience in the same direction beats heroic bursts.
5. The best version of you is the one your future self and your closest people will thank you for.

PART II

The Action Guide

Diagnose. Design. Defend.

PART II

The Get Me There Action Guide

A practical playbook drawn from the whole book — what to do, in order.

If you've already wandered into the Stress Spiral — or you can feel its pull — here's the path back. Three phases: **Diagnose** (see the spiral honestly), **Design** (build the Thrive Cycle), and **Defend** (recalibrate when life pushes back). Work through each phase in order.

PHASE 1

Diagnose: tell the truth about where you are

Step 1 — Name the spiral.

Audit yourself against the Stress Spiral's three legs. Where is your time unfocused? Where is your energy unleveraged? Where are your priorities being hijacked? Be specific — name the exact meetings, inboxes, and people that are draining you.

Step 2 — Stop saying "I don't have time."

Replace it internally with *I didn't make the time*. If you didn't make time for the gym, your spouse, or your dream, you chose other things. That's a fixable problem; "no time" is not.

Step 3 — Burn the script.

The cultural script that says exhaustion is the price of success has to go. Decide that overwhelm is no longer your normal. Without that decision, every later step rolls back.

Step 4 — Build a Dream List.

Write down 3-5 people, projects, or pursuits you wish you had more time for, and how many hours per week you'd want for each. This becomes the destination your Thrive Calendar is built toward.

PHASE 2

Design: build the Thrive Cycle

Step 5 — Map your Energy Clock.

For one to two weeks, track your productivity and your mood by hour. Find your 3-5 peak hours (Green Zone), your moderate hours (Yellow Zone), and your low-energy hours (Red Zone). Don't inflate the Green Zone — three leveraged hours beat ten unleveraged.

Step 6 — Define your Optimal Green Zone Focus.

Find the intersection of **Gifting** (what comes easy to you and hard to others), **Passion** (what energizes you), and **Impact** (what moves the needle most). That intersection is what belongs in your Green Zone — and what you should spend ~30 minutes a day *developing*, not just delivering.

Step 7 — Build your Thrive Calendar.

Pre-decide using four questions: **What** will you do in each zone? **Who** will you meet with? **When** will you do specific kinds of work? **Where** will Green Zone work happen? Set these as repeating appointments with yourself. White space is a trap; pre-decision is freedom.

Step 8 — Pareto your tasks and people.

Identify the 20% of work that produces 80% of results — that's where Green Zone goes. Identify your top 3-5 (inner circle) and 12-15 (close circle) — that's where 80% of relational time goes. Healthy at the top, healthy at the bottom.

Step 9 — Engineer the environment.

Find or build the most undistracted space you can for Green Zone work. Turn off all notifications by default. Schedule motion (walks, runs) into the day for thinking. Sleep 7-9 hours. The body delivers the brain.

PHASE 3

Defend: protect the cycle when life pushes back

Step 10 — Master the clear no.

Use the five-step pattern: (1) *I'd love to*, (2) empathy, (3) firm decline, (4) redirect to a better fit, (5) thank them. Reasons are optional; the no is not.

Step 11 — Make categorical decisions.

Eliminate whole categories rather than deciding one request at a time: no breakfast meetings, no weekend work, only certain audiences, pre-chosen charities. One decision quietly removes hundreds of future ones.

Step 12 — Match response speed to relationship depth.

Inner circle within the hour. Close circle same day. Wider 150 within 48 hours or via team. Everyone else later or not at all. The depth of your response should track the depth of the relationship.

Step 13 — Anticipate, then recalibrate.

When a change is coming (new role, new baby, move, loss, growth), redesign *before* it lands. When change surprises you, audit your time fast and rebuild your zones. Treat your calendar like a 300,000-mile SUV: preventative maintenance beats roadside breakdowns.

Step 14 — Do the math on three ratios.

Periodically check three quiet governors of sustainability: (a) **alone vs. with people**, (b) **time in meetings** (and your weekly meeting cap), (c) **home vs. on the road**. When any ratio drifts past your tolerance, adjust before stress reappears.

Step 15 — Aim at who you're becoming, not just what you're producing.

The Thrive Cycle's deepest payoff is character: a kinder, more present, more focused you over decades. Productivity is the side effect. Make sure the future you would thank the present you for the choices you're making today.

QUICK REFERENCE: ALL PRINCIPLES IN ONE PLACE

- Survival is not a worthy goal. Thriving is.
- A sustainable pace is the only solution to an unsustainable pace.
- Live in a way today that will help you thrive tomorrow.
- Stress Spiral = unfocused time + unleveraged energy + hijacked priorities.
- Thrive Cycle = focused time + leveraged energy + realized priorities.
- Tell the truth about time: "I didn't make the time" beats "I don't have the time."
- Balance is a retreat. Passion (curated, filtered) is the way forward.
- You only have 3-5 truly peak hours per day. Find them. Protect them.

- Optimal Green Zone Focus = Gifting x Passion x Impact.
- Develop your gift; don't just use it. The 30-minute compound rule.
- Yellow Zone for moderate work. Red Zone for low-stakes work and exercise.
- Never make important decisions in your Red Zone.
- You control more of your week than you think — usually 88%+.
- Nobody asks you to do your priorities — they ask you to do theirs.
- Pareto your tasks: 20% of activities produce 80% of results.
- Pareto your relationships: 80% of time on top performers and inner circle.
- Master the 5-step clear no. Reasons optional; the no is not.
- Make categorical decisions. One choice eliminates hundreds.
- Notifications off. Environment quiet. Motion as a thinking tool. Sleep as a weapon.
- Dunbar's circles: protect your 3-5, your 12-15, your 150 — in that order.
- Match response speed to relationship depth.
- Blank space on a calendar is a trap. Pre-decision is freedom.
- When change is coming, redesign before it lands.
- Watch three ratios: alone vs people, time in meetings, home vs road.
- It's not just what you accomplish — it's who you're becoming.